
Does Statutory Structure Help? Retrieving Every Indispensable Provision for Sri Lankan Conveyancing Scenarios

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Abstract

1 A conveyancing question is answered only when every provision it turns on is in
2 hand: the operative rule, the definition it relies on and the exception that decides the
3 case. We ask whether structure-aware retrieval finds these complete sets better than
4 flat retrieval does, in Sri Lanka, where prior work is scored on questions generated
5 from the Act text. We build a corpus of 52 principal enactments and 60 amending
6 Acts (4,557 sections, 6,346 typed edges for definitions, exceptions, qualifications,
7 cross-references and amendments); a benchmark of 50 questions in 40 fact patterns
8 from Sri Lanka Law College conveyancing examinations, each mapped to the
9 sections indispensable to a complete answer with verbatim provenance; and seven
10 retrievers, from BM25 to a hierarchical system that routes to Acts, retrieves seed
11 sections and expands them along the typed edges. The principal metric, complete-
12 indispensable recall, credits a question only when every indispensable section
13 is retrieved. Structure does not help: complete recall at 20 is 0.344 for hybrid
14 BM25 and dense fusion and 0.312 for the structure-aware retriever, with a paired
15 matter-level bootstrap interval that includes zero. No system completes a question
16 needing four or more sections, and only two of the sections the structure-aware
17 retriever missed were reachable by any typed edge from a retrieved seed: the
18 gold dependencies are jointly required provisions that no cross-reference wording
19 connects. Gold labels are agent-produced and agent-verified and are released as
20 proposed gold pending a three-attorney validation whose protocol we specify.

21 1 Introduction

22 Whether a Sri Lankan notary may attest a deed outside the notary’s judicial zone turns on several
23 provisions at once: the rule limiting territorial authority, the provision allocating responsibility when
24 two notaries participate, and the Prevention of Frauds Ordinance provision governing the validity
25 of notarial execution. Retrieving one or two of them yields an answer that looks grounded and is
26 legally incomplete, so statutory retrieval should be judged on whether it returns the complete bundle
27 a question needs.

28 Legal retrieval benchmarks have mostly scored cases or passages independently [Paul et al., 2025,
29 Pipitone and Alami, 2024]. Statute-oriented resources now pose scenario questions whose facts share
30 little vocabulary with the controlling text [Zheng et al., 2025]: KoBLEX contains provision-grounded
31 multi-hop questions [Lee et al., 2025], GreekBarRetrieval pairs bar-examination questions with the
32 articles in official solutions [Beta et al., 2026], and others study structure-aware [Chae et al., 2026]
33 and temporally sensitive [Prior et al., 2026] statutory retrieval. None jointly separates indispensable
34 from supporting provisions, scores with an all-or-nothing bundle measure, and tests through matched
35 ablations whether typed statutory relationships help. For Sri Lanka, LawChain retrieves over Acts

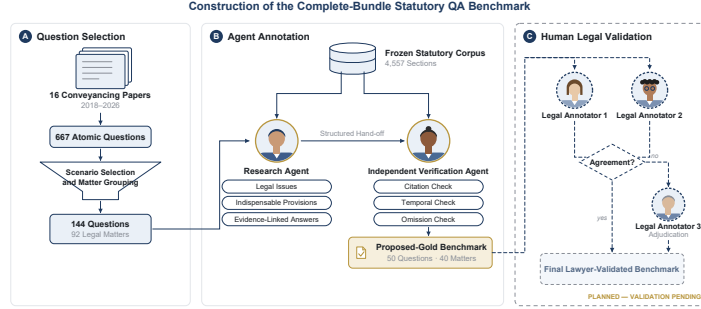


Figure 1: Benchmark construction. Automated stages (solid) are complete; the three-rater legal validation (dashed) is planned and pending.

with BM25, dense embeddings and a Neo4j graph [Atukorala et al., 2026], but its questions are generated from the legislative text, judged by Gemini, and need one provision each; Athulathmudali [2025] retrieve over scenario records rather than sections; ScaLe-QA [Jayawardena et al., 2024] trains embeddings on judgments without a section-level benchmark.

We ask: does structure-aware retrieval improve recall of every legally indispensable provision for scenario questions in a low-resource jurisdiction? We contribute (1) an expert-informed corpus of Sri Lankan conveyancing and notarial legislation linking enactments, sections, amending Acts and typed relationships; (2) a benchmark from sixteen Law College examination papers whose gold maps separate indispensable, supporting and background provisions and tie answer claims to verbatim statutory text (§2); and (3) an evaluation of lexical, dense, hybrid, hierarchical and provision-bundle retrievers under complete-indispensable recall with matched ablations and matter-level uncertainty (§3, §4). The extracted structure does not beat strong hybrid retrieval, because indispensable provisions are jointly required without any cross-reference wording connecting them. The gold is agent-produced and agent-verified; attorney validation has not run, so every number here is a measurement against proposed gold (§5).

2 Corpus and benchmark

Corpus. The principal enactments are the 52 statutes named in the Sri Lanka Law College conveyancing course tables; we then collected their amending Acts (Appendix G). The corpus is built deterministically from structured JSON trees parsed from Government Printer and private-republisher PDFs and checked structurally, not legally: 52 consolidated principal enactments, 60 amending Acts kept as separate documents so amendment relationships have a source node, 4,557 sections (the retrieval and scoring unit) and 17,854 sub-section provisions. Six edge types (6,346 edges) are derived from the trees: cross-references are typed by the wording around them into `DEFINES`, `EXCEPTS`, `QUALIFIES`, `PROCEDURALLY_REQUIRES` or `CROSS_REFERENCES`; a section that uses a term defined in the same Act gets a `DEFINES` edge to the defining section (3,780 edges, the bulk of the graph); `AMENDS` edges link amending sections to the principal sections they change. Each section carries the year it came into force, which the temporal filter uses. The cue-word typing is a heuristic and is ablated (Appendix A).

Questions and annotation. We start from 667 atomic questions split out of sixteen Sri Lanka Law College conveyancing papers (2018 to 2026); 210 classified keep or enrich form the candidate pool. Questions sharing a fact pattern form a matter and are never split across agents, dataset splits or bootstrap samples. After quarantining 18 for background-boundary problems and sending 66 to manual review, Tier A holds 144 questions in 92 matters, each dated by its exam session so that “the law in force” is fixed. Each matter was researched by one agent (Claude Opus 5, tool access limited to a search interface over the frozen corpus) and checked by a second agent that had not seen the research (Figure 1). The researcher classifies the authority requirement (statute only, mixed, case only, unclear), records every provision with a verbatim excerpt that a validator checks against the corpus, labels it indispensable, supporting or background, counts legal hops, drafts an answer with per-claim provenance and, for enrich questions, adds labelled synthetic facts. The verifier

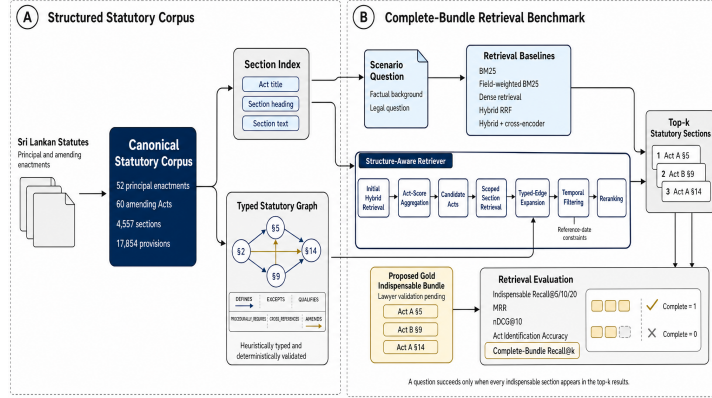


Figure 2: (A) The corpus yields a section index and a typed statutory graph. (B) A scenario question is answered by five flat baselines and by the structure-aware retriever; the top- k sections are scored against the proposed gold bundle, and a question counts only when every indispensable section is retrieved.

re-reads every cited section, checks role, temporal applicability and omissions along the corpus edges, and marks it verified, partially verified, rejected or unresolved. A question enters the benchmark only if it is statute-only, every indispensable provision is verified or partially verified, and the map validates: 50 questions in 40 matters, 23 statutes, 84 distinct indispensable sections, 17 questions spanning more than one Act, 31 needing three or more sections (funnel in Appendix B; one record in Appendix C). Questions needing case law are reserved, not forced into a statute-only answer. The split is by matter: development 8 matters (10 questions), test 32 (40). Agent agreement is not legal validation, so the gold is labelled proposed: three attorneys-at-law will rate independently from the shipped review packets, with two-of-three agreement on every indispensable provision required for inclusion (Appendix B); no rating has been collected at the time of writing.

3 Retrieval systems

All systems take the same query, the normalised background (enriched where enrichment applied) followed by the question, and return sections (Figure 2; settings in Appendix D). S1 is BM25 over title, heading and body [Robertson and Zaragoza, 2009]. S2 is field-weighted BM25 over Act title, part heading, section heading, body, defined terms and cross-reference text. S3 is dense retrieval with bge-base-en-v1.5 [Xiao et al., 2024], scoring long sections by the maximum over overlapping windows. S4 fuses S2 and S3 by reciprocal rank fusion [Cormack et al., 2009]. S5 reranks the top 100 of S4 with the MS MARCO MiniLM cross-encoder [Wang et al., 2020, Reimers and Gurevych, 2019]. S6 follows the document-then-passage structure of HiREC [Choe et al., 2025]: Acts are scored by the sum of their top five fused section scores (amending Acts fold into their principal), the top 3 Acts are kept, and hybrid retrieval is rerun inside them. S7, the structure-aware retriever, takes the top 15 routed sections as seeds, adds every target of an enabled typed edge to the pool with support accumulating over seeds, drops sections not in force at the matter’s reference date, reranks with the same cross-encoder, and scores by the average of the normalised reranker and fused scores plus $\gamma \log(1 + \text{support})$, $\gamma = 0.15$. Everything except the reranker and the embedding model is deterministic, and each component is switched off in turn.

4 Results

Metrics. Indispensable recall at k ($R@k$) is the share of a question’s indispensable sections in the top k . Complete-indispensable recall ($C@k$), the principal metric, is 1 only when all of them are retrieved, the set-level exact match of KoBLEX [Lee et al., 2025] at a cutoff. We also report MRR of the first indispensable section, nDCG@10 (gain 2 indispensable, 1 supporting) and Act identification accuracy at 10. Questions from one matter are averaged first; means and 95% intervals are matter-level bootstraps (2,000 resamples) and comparisons are paired. Hyperparameters were chosen on the development split; Table 1 is the test split.

Table 1: Test split (40 questions, 32 matters), matter-macro means. R = indispensable recall, C = complete-indispensable recall, Act = Act identification accuracy. Bootstrap intervals in Appendix F.

System	R@10	R@20	C@10	C@20	MRR	nDCG@10	Act@10
BM25	0.452	0.491	0.250	0.281	0.503	0.345	0.719
Field-weighted BM25	0.456	0.482	0.250	0.281	0.540	0.361	0.672
Dense (bge-base)	0.282	0.379	0.125	0.188	0.316	0.186	0.562
BM25F + dense (RRF)	0.454	0.546	0.266	0.344	0.543	0.372	0.625
Hybrid + cross-encoder	0.250	0.413	0.125	0.234	0.223	0.185	0.562
Hierarchical Act→section	0.447	0.496	0.297	0.375	0.509	0.357	0.469
Hierarchical + bundle (ours)	0.454	0.480	0.281	0.312	0.495	0.334	0.469

Main result. Fusing field-weighted BM25 with dense retrieval (S4) is the strongest system on R@20 (0.546) and on Act identification, and it ties the hierarchical systems on complete recall: S6 reaches C@20 of 0.375 and S7 0.312, against 0.344 for S4, and every pairwise difference among S4, S6 and S7 has a bootstrap interval that includes zero (Appendix F). Two components hurt. The web-trained cross-encoder (S5) drops MRR from 0.543 to 0.223 and C@10 to 0.125. Act routing with three retained Acts contains every gold Act on only 44% of test questions (12 of 40 need two or more Acts), so Act identification falls from 0.625 (S4) to 0.469 (S6, S7), while correctly routed questions are retrieved more completely, which is why C@20 holds. Dense retrieval alone is weak (C@20 0.188) but lifts BM25 in fusion (R@20 from 0.482 to 0.546). None of this is comparable with LawChain’s recall at 5 of 0.94 [Atukorala et al., 2026], which asks only whether the one source Act of a generated question is in the top five.

Ablations and errors. Removing typed expansion, the dense channel, amendment edges or the reranker from S7 each lowers C@20 by one question in 32 matters; removing definition, exception or cross-reference edges individually changes nothing; removing the temporal filter gains one question whose gold is a 2022 amending section that recites superseded wording (Appendix E). No difference is separable from zero. Across systems C@20 is 0.33 to 1.0 on the three test questions with one indispensable section, 0.25 to 0.67 on the twelve with two, 0.2 to 0.4 on the five with three, and 0.0 on all twenty with four or more. Of the 114 indispensable sections S7 left outside its top 20, two were reachable by a single typed edge from any retrieved seed: the graph is dominated by term-matching definition edges (3,780 of 6,346), while the gold dependencies are jointly required provisions that no cross-reference string connects. Enriched scenarios, whose added facts name the conditions the provisions test, are easier than the originals (C@20 0.43 against 0.11 for S7).

5 Limitations

The gold is proposed, not validated. 36 Tier A questions were blocked because the governing text (schedules, stamp duty orders, Roman-Dutch principles) is not in the corpus and 38 case-law questions were reserved, so the benchmark under-represents the hardest questions; the test split has 32 matters, so intervals are wide. Edge typing is an unmeasured cue-word heuristic, temporal filtering uses insertion years rather than version histories, and answer generation is not scored. The benchmark measures retrievers, not legal advice: anything scored on it returns unverified statutory text that a lawyer must check.

6 Conclusion and future work

On this benchmark, Act routing and typed-edge expansion as extracted here do not improve complete recall over hybrid BM25 and dense fusion, and no system completes a question that needs four or more sections. The gap is coverage, not ranking: jointly required provisions are rarely joined by cross-reference wording. Three steps follow. First, complete the three-attorney validation (Appendix B) and release validated gold with agreement statistics, so every number here can be re-measured against lawyer-approved labels. Second, fine-tune the dense retriever and cross-encoder on Sri Lankan statutory text, since the web-trained reranker halved MRR. Third, widen the benchmark to the reserved case-law questions, more matters and Acts, and more systems: query expansion, SPLADE and LLM query rewriting, which the enriched scenarios suggest matter most.

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205 A Corpus construction

206 Cross-references are typed by the wording around them: “within the meaning of” becomes DEFINES,
 207 “notwithstanding” and “shall not apply” become EXCEPTS (106 edges), “subject to” becomes QUALI-
 208 FIES (131), “in the manner prescribed” and “under section” become PROCEDURALLY_REQUIRES
 209 (1,153), and anything else stays CROSS_REFERENCES (847). Term-matching DEFINES edges number
 210 3,780 and AMENDS edges 329; 954 sections have at least one amendment. 4,138 of the 4,557 sections
 211 belong to principal enactments; provisions are kept for display and gold excerpts. Each section carries
 212 the year it came into force (the Act’s year, or the inserting amendment’s). The corpus fingerprint is
 213 f119236b806f.

214 B Benchmark funnel and validation protocol

Table 2: Benchmark funnel and gold statistics. All gold is proposed and pending lawyer validation.

Funnel	questions	Gold set
source atomic questions	667	questions / matters 50 / 40
keep or enrich candidates	210	enrich questions 25
Tier A (clean, confident)	144	statutes represented 23
annotated by agents	144	distinct indispensable sections 84
statute-only, proposed gold	50	hop count 1 / 2 / 3+ 1 / 10 / 39
reserved (mixed or case law)	38	indispensable sections per question 1 / 2 / 3+ 3 / 16 / 31
blocked (missing authority, ambiguity)	36	questions with >1 gold Act 17
eligible after verification	50	lawyer approved 0

215 **Annotation checks.** A deterministic validator (no LLM) checks every legal map against a JSON
 216 schema and the corpus: each cited section exists and its Act, number and title agree with the
 217 corpus row; each excerpt is a verbatim substring of the section body; indispensable, supporting and
 218 background sets are disjoint; a proposed-gold question has at least one indispensable provision, a hop
 219 count of at least one, and no case-law citation in its answer; enrich questions carry labelled synthetic
 220 facts and keep questions carry none. A verification report and a disagreement log are written per
 221 matter. Review packets and empty approval forms ship with the data.

222 **Legal validation protocol.** The validation follows the human stage of KoBLEX [Lee et al., 2025],
 223 adapted to the provision as the unit. Three raters, all attorneys-at-law, work independently from the
 224 review packets. For every indispensable provision they answer two questions: is this the correct
 225 authority for the claim it supports, and could the question be answered completely without it. For
 226 every question they answer three more: is the statute-only classification correct, is any indispensable
 227 provision missing, and how legally accurate is the draft answer on a five-point scale. A question
 228 enters the validated set only when at least two of three raters agree on every indispensable provision
 229 and on statute-only status; disagreements go to adjudication rather than to a silent majority. We will
 230 report raw agreement, Fleiss’ κ , and the number of agent-proposed provisions rejected, added or
 231 relabelled, which is itself a measurement of agent-produced legal gold.

232 C A benchmark question

233 One development-split question, rendered from the public-input and private-gold records. Test-split
234 questions are not printed. Every gold element below is agent-produced and awaits the validation in
235 Appendix B.

236 **Public input.** Question M027-Q01, paper 4, October 2024 sitting; reference date 2024-10; enrichment not
237 applied.

238 *Background.* Kanthi Peiris is a Notary practicing in Colombo. Shantha Ratnayake is her
239 brother-in-law and is the owner of an apartment in Negambo. Shantha wishes to lease out
240 his apartment for 3 years at a monthly rental of Rs.120,000/= to one Ananda Gamage who
241 is willing to take on lease in accordance with the said terms. However, Shantha who lives in
242 Negambo is unable to come to Colombo to sign the Agreement.

243 *Question.* How can this Agreement be signed by both parties and what steps should Kanthi
244 follow with regard to the registration of this Agreement?

245 **Proposed gold (private view).** Authority requirement STATUTE ONLY; legal hop count 4; gold Acts 1-1907,
246 23-1927, 7-1840; status PROPOSED GOLD, lawyer validation PENDING.

- 247 1. Whether a three-year lease of an apartment must be executed notarially, and in whose presence the
248 lessor and lessee must sign.
- 249 2. How the agreement can be validly signed when the lessor cannot attend before the Colombo notary -
250 execution before more than one notary at different times and places, or execution by a duly authorised
251 attorney under a registered power of attorney.
- 252 3. What registration steps the notary must take for a lease of land situated in a district other than the one
253 in which she resides and practises, and within what time.

Indispensable provision	Excerpt checked verbatim against the corpus
Prevention of Frauds Ordinance No. 7 of 1840, s. 2(1)(a)	shall be in force or avail in law unless - (a) the relevant deed or instrument shall be in writing, signed by every executant or by any person duly authorised by such executant and the witnesses in the presence of a lic. . .
Notaries Ordinance No. 1 of 1907, s. 31 rule (12)	(12) He shall not authenticate or attest any deed or instrument unless the person executing the same and the witnesses shall have signed the same in his presence and in the presence of one another, and unless he shall h. . .
Notaries Ordinance No. 1 of 1907, s. 31 rule (22)	(22) He shall not authenticate or attest any deed or instrument in any area other than that in which he is authorized to practice, nor in any language other than that in which he is authorized to practice nor authentica. . .
Notaries Ordinance No. 1 of 1907, s. 31 rule (25)	(25) Where any deed or instrument is executed or acknowledged before more than one notary- (a) the notary who first attests such deed or instrument shall comply with all the requirements of rule (20), and every other no. . .
254 Notaries Ordinance No. 1 of 1907, s. 32(2)(i)	(2) In the case of any deed or instrument which is to be executed by two or more parties, both or all of whom, as the case may be, do not sign the deed or instrument at the same time and place- (i) the deed or instrumen. . .
Notaries Ordinance No. 1 of 1907, s. 31 rule (30A)	(30A) It shall be the duty of every notary to submit for registration to the Registrar, every deed or instrument attested by him before the expiry of thirty days from the date of attestation thereof: Provided that, wher. . .
Registration of Documents Ordinance No. 23 of 1927, s. 8(b)	(b) if executed or made after the commencement of this Ordinance, all instruments, including wills, decrees and orders of any court or authority, and awards, which purport or operate to create, confer, declare, limit, a. . .
Registration of Documents Ordinance No. 23 of 1927, s. 14(1)	(1) Every instrument presented for registration shall be registered in the book allotted to the division in which the land affected by the instrument is situated
Notaries Ordinance No. 1 of 1907, s. 2	Every appointment to the office of notary shall be by warrant granted by the Minister, and shall specify the area within which, and the language or languages in which, the person appointed is authorized to practice.

255 Supporting (not scored): 1-1907/s37, 23-1927/s26, 23-1927/s7, 4-1902/s2, 4-1902/s3, 4-1902/s3A, 4-1902/s3B.

256 Reasoning edges (source → target):

	JOINTLY REQUIRED	7-1840/s2 → 1-1907/s31; 23-1927/s8 → 23-1927/s14
	QUALIFIES	1-1907/s31 → 1-1907/s32; 23-1927/s8 → 23-1927/s7
257	PROCEDURALLY REQUIRES	7-1840/s2 → 1-1907/s31; 1-1907/s31 → 23-1927/s14
	CROSS REFERENCES	1-1907/s31 → 4-1902/s2; 4-1902/s3A → 7-1840/s2
	DEFINES	1-1907/s2 → 1-1907/s31

258 **Draft answer (agent-written, unvalidated).** *Issue.* How a three-year lease of a Negombo apartment at
259 Rs.120,000 a month can be signed by a lessor who cannot come to Colombo and by a lessee who can, and what
260 a Colombo notary must then do to register the instrument.

261 *Rule.* A lease of immovable property for a period exceeding one month is of no force in law unless it is in
262 writing, signed by every executant, or by a person duly authorised by the executant, and by the witnesses in
263 the presence of a licenced notary present at the same time and in the presence of one another, and attested by
264 that notary (Prevention of Frauds Ordinance s.2(1)(a)). The notary may not attest unless the executant and the
265 witnesses signed in her presence and in the presence of one another (Notaries Ordinance s.31 rule (12)), and
266 she may not attest in any area other than the area in which she is authorised to practise (s.31 rule (22)). The
267 Ordinance nevertheless contemplates a deed executed or acknowledged before more than one notary and divides
268 the attestation duties between the first attesting notary and every other attesting notary (s.31 rule (25)), and
269 s.32(2) provides for parties who do not sign at the same time and place, deeming the instrument executed for the
270 purposes of rules (6), (7), (23) and (25) when it is first signed. Alternatively the lessor may authorise an attorney:
271 a power of attorney executed in Sri Lanka must be executed before two witnesses and attested by a notary
272 (Powers of Attorney Ordinance s.2), must meet the additional requirements of s.3A where the transaction falls
273 within s.2 of the Prevention of Frauds Ordinance, must be submitted for registration with the Registrar-General
274 within one month (s.3(1)(b)), and the attesting notary must check the Registrar-General's volumes and folios
275 and state in her attestation that it has not been revoked (s.3B), keep a true copy with her protocol and forward a
276 copy with the duplicate (Notaries Ordinance s.31 rule (30)), and take the attorney's affidavit that the power is
277 genuine, in force and the grantor alive. As to registration, an instrument creating an interest in land is deemed to
278 affect land and so is registrable (Registration of Documents Ordinance s.8(b)), an unregistered instrument is
279 void against a subsequent duly registered instrument taken for value (s.7(1)), registration must be effected in the
280 book allotted to the division in which the land is situated (s.14(1)), and the notary acting for a party may present
281 it (s.26(1)(d)). The notary must submit the deed for registration within thirty days of attestation, or sixty days
282 where it is to be registered outside the jurisdiction in which she practises (Notaries Ordinance s.31 rule (30A)),
283 send the duplicate and Form F1 list to the Registrar of Lands of her own district by the fifteenth of the following
284 month (rule (26)), send a certified copy to the Registrar of Lands of the district where the land lies (rule (29)),
285 and use due diligence in registering where she has instructions and funds (s.37).

286 *Application.* The lease is for three years, well outside the one-month exclusion, so notarial execution is
287 compulsory and Shantha cannot simply sign at home and send the paper to Colombo. Kanthi practises in
288 Colombo and the apartment and Shantha are in Negombo, so rule (22) prevents her attesting Shantha's signature
289 outside the area she is authorised for. Two lawful routes remain. First, execution before more than one notary
290 under rule (25): Ananda Gamage signs the agreement before Kanthi in Colombo with two witnesses, and
291 Shantha signs the same instrument before a notary authorised to practise where he is, each notary attesting
292 the signatures taken before her or him, each numbering the instrument in his or her own protocol register, and
293 s.32(2) accommodating the fact that the parties sign at different times and places. Second, Shantha grants a
294 power of attorney, attested by a notary before two witnesses and complying with s.3A because the lease falls
295 within s.2 of the Prevention of Frauds Ordinance, registers it with the Registrar-General within one month, and
296 his attorney then signs before Kanthi in Colombo along with Ananda; Kanthi must satisfy herself from the
297 Registrar-General's volumes and folios that the power stands unrevoked and say so in her attestation, take the
298 attorney's affidavit, and keep and forward copies of the power. Either way she must have an assurance that the
299 stamp duty is provided before attesting. On registration, the lease creates an interest in land and is registrable; it
300 must go to the land registry for the division in which the Negombo apartment is situated, not Colombo. Because
301 that registration is outside the jurisdiction in which Kanthi practises, she has sixty days from attestation to submit
302 it, she must transmit the duplicate and Form F1 list to the Registrar of Lands of her own district by the fifteenth
303 of the following month, and she must send a certified copy to the Registrar of Lands of the district in which the
304 apartment lies. If the apartment forms part of a registered Condominium Property, she should also check whether
305 the interest has to be registered under the Registration of Title Act rather than in the ordinary land register. The
306 scenario does not state Shantha's judicial zone, whether the apartment is registered condominium property, or
307 whether the parties have instructed and funded Kanthi to register, so those points are stated conditionally.

308 *Conclusion.* The agreement can be signed either before two notaries at different times and places, Ananda before
309 Kanthi in Colombo and Shantha before a notary where he is, or by an attorney holding a duly attested and
310 registered power of attorney signing for Shantha before Kanthi. Kanthi must then have the duty stamped, submit
311 the instrument for registration in the land registry division covering the Negombo apartment within sixty days
312 of attestation, transmit the duplicate with the Form F1 list to the Registrar of Lands of her own district by the
313 fifteenth of the following month, and send a certified copy to the Registrar of Lands of the district where the
314 apartment is situated.

315 Claim-level provenance, first two of 16:

316 rule A lease of immovable property for a period exceeding one month is of no force in law unless it is in
 317 writing, signed by every executant or a person duly authorised by the executant and by the witnesses
 318 in the presence of a licenced notary, and attested by that notary. $\leftarrow$ 7-1840/s2, 1-1907/s31, 7-1840/s2
 319 rule A notary may not attest a deed unless the executant and the witnesses signed it in her presence and in
 320 the presence of one another. $\leftarrow$ 1-1907/s31

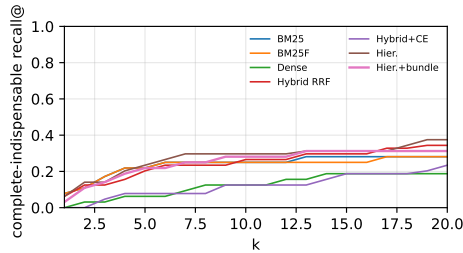
321 D Configuration and compute

322 All runs: corpus fingerprint f119236b806f, run `main-test`, git commit e491f2d26f, CPU only.

- 323 • BM25: $k_1 = 1.2$, $b = 0.75$, tokenizer [0-9a-z]+ after case folding, closed-class stopwords list. Field
 324 weights (S2, S4-S7): act title 3.0, part heading 1.0, section heading 4.0, body 1.0, defined terms 2.0,
 325 cross-reference text 0.5.
- 326 • Dense: BAAI/bge-base-en-v1.5, cosine similarity, query prefix “Represent this sentence for search-
 327 ing relevant passages:”, windows of 1500 characters with stride 1200, at most 12 windows per section,
 328 section score = max over windows.
- 329 • Fusion: reciprocal rank fusion with $k = 60$, equal channel weights, candidate depth 100.
- 330 • Reranker: cross-encoder/ms-marco-MiniLM-L-6-v2, max length 512, passage = act title, head-
 331 ing and the first 2000 characters of the section.
- 332 • Routing (S6, S7): Acts scored by the sum of the top 5 fused section scores; 3 Acts retained; amending
 333 Acts folded into their principal enactment.
- 334 • Bundle (S7): 15 seeds; expansion over defines, excepts, qualifies, cross_references, procedu-
 335 rally_requires, amends; temporal filter on; graph-support weight $\gamma = 0.15$; seed bonus 0.05.
- 336 • Query: normalised background (enriched where enrichment applied) followed by the question. Split
 337 seed 13, development fraction 0.17. Bootstrap: 2,000 matter-level resamples, seed 13.

338 All runs used a single consumer laptop CPU (Windows 11, Python 3.12, PyTorch 2.13 CPU build, no GPU).
 339 Wall-clock time over the 40 test queries: BM25 and BM25F under 1 s each, dense retrieval 28 s, hybrid fusion
 340 0.7 s, hybrid with cross-encoder 276 s, Act routing 1.4 s, the bundle retriever 37 s; the ten ablations together 93 s.
 341 Corpus embedding with bge-base-en-v1.5 is cached once per corpus fingerprint. Development tuning and
 342 smoke runs used the same machine.

343 E Ablations and recall curves



Variant	C@10	C@20	R@20
Full system	0.281	0.312	0.480
without expansion	0.281	0.281	0.452
without act routing	0.297	0.297	0.518
without field weights	0.281	0.312	0.470
without dense	0.281	0.281	0.439
without temporal	0.281	0.344	0.496
without defines	0.281	0.312	0.480
without excepts qualifies	0.281	0.312	0.473
without xref procedural	0.281	0.312	0.475
without amends	0.281	0.281	0.465
without rerank	0.281	0.281	0.454

Figure 3: Left: complete-indispensable recall against the cutoff k on the test split. The curves of the hybrid and hierarchical systems cross repeatedly and none clears 0.4 at $k = 20$. Right: ablations of S7 (matter-macro means); no removal changes C@20 by more than one question in 32 matters.

344 Removing Act routing raises R@20 (0.518 against 0.480) while lowering C@20 by half a point. Removing
 345 the temporal filter raises C@20 to 0.344 because of one question: its gold cites a section of a 2022 amending
 346 Act that recites the 2019 wording of a rule the consolidated text no longer carries, so the filter that removes
 347 anachronistic law removes the only copy of the applicable text.

F Confidence intervals

System	R@20	C@10	C@20	MRR
BM25	0.49 [0.35, 0.62]	0.25 [0.09, 0.41]	0.28 [0.12, 0.44]	0.50 [0.36, 0.65]
BM25F	0.48 [0.35, 0.61]	0.25 [0.09, 0.41]	0.28 [0.12, 0.44]	0.54 [0.38, 0.70]
Dense	0.38 [0.25, 0.50]	0.12 [0.03, 0.25]	0.19 [0.06, 0.34]	0.32 [0.19, 0.45]
Hybrid RRF	0.55 [0.41, 0.68]	0.27 [0.12, 0.42]	0.34 [0.19, 0.50]	0.54 [0.40, 0.69]
Hybrid + CE	0.41 [0.29, 0.54]	0.12 [0.03, 0.23]	0.23 [0.11, 0.39]	0.22 [0.14, 0.32]
Hierarchical	0.50 [0.34, 0.64]	0.30 [0.16, 0.45]	0.38 [0.22, 0.53]	0.51 [0.35, 0.66]
Hier. + bundle	0.48 [0.34, 0.63]	0.28 [0.12, 0.44]	0.31 [0.16, 0.47]	0.50 [0.36, 0.64]

Paired matter-level bootstrap differences, S7 minus the named system (95% CI), for complete recall at 20 and indispensable recall at 20:

- vs BM25: $\Delta C@20$ +0.031 [-0.062, +0.125], $\Delta R@20$ -0.011 [-0.100, +0.076]
- vs BM25F: $\Delta C@20$ +0.031 [-0.062, +0.125], $\Delta R@20$ -0.002 [-0.092, +0.084]
- vs Dense: $\Delta C@20$ +0.125 [+0.031, +0.250], $\Delta R@20$ +0.101 [-0.018, +0.229]
- vs Hybrid RRF: $\Delta C@20$ -0.031 [-0.156, +0.078], $\Delta R@20$ -0.065 [-0.156, +0.026]
- vs Hybrid + CE: $\Delta C@20$ +0.078 [-0.062, +0.234], $\Delta R@20$ +0.068 [-0.040, +0.187]
- vs Hierarchical: $\Delta C@20$ -0.062 [-0.156, -0.000], $\Delta R@20$ -0.016 [-0.060, +0.021]

G Statutes in the corpus

Table 3 lists every principal enactment in the frozen corpus (fingerprint f119236b806f) with the number of amending Acts the corpus holds for it. The enactments are the 52 statutes named in the Sri Lanka Law College conveyancing course tables, which rank them in three categories; the amending Acts are those whose own text was available as a separate document, so the count reflects source availability, not the full amendment history.

Table 3: Principal enactments in the frozen corpus (52), by year. Cat. is the curriculum category assigned by the Sri Lanka Law College conveyancing course tables (1 most important, 3 important). Sections are the retrieval units the parser produced. Amend. is the number of amending Acts held in the corpus as separate documents whose AMENDS edges point to the enactment (60 in total, of which 9 record no target and are not counted). Fold. is the number of amending instruments already folded into the consolidated text. Edition is the text the section tree was built from.

Enactment	Cat.	Sections	Amend.	Fold.	Edition
Prevention of Frauds Ordinance No. 7 of 1840	1	19	2	5	consolidated
State Lands Encroachments Ordinance No. 12 of 1840	3	10	0	3	consolidated
Definition of Boundaries Ordinance No. 1 of 1844	2	14	0	5	consolidated
Wills Ordinance No. 21 of 1844	1	7	1	5	consolidated
Deeds and Documents (Execution before Public Officers) Ordinance No. 17 of 1852	1	7	0	1	consolidated
Land Surveys Ordinance No. 4 of 1866	3	7	0	1	consolidated
Sannases and Old Deeds Ordinance No. 6 of 1866	3	10	0	1	consolidated
Prescription Ordinance No. 22 of 1871	1	15	1	2	consolidated
Matrimonial Rights and Inheritance Ordinance No. 15 of 1876	1	36	0	1	consolidated
Lands Resumption Ordinance No. 4 of 1887	3	17	0	3	consolidated
Civil Procedure Code No. 2 of 1889	1	798	0	55	consolidated
Surveyors Ordinance No. 15 of 1889	3	20	0	6	consolidated
Powers of Attorney Ordinance No. 4 of 1902	1	17	3	6	consolidated
Notaries Ordinance No. 1 of 1907	1	42	5	19	consolidated
Jaffna Matrimonial Rights and Inheritance Ordinance No. 1 of 1911	1	40	0	1	consolidated
Trusts Ordinance No. 9 of 1917	3	123	1	5	consolidated
Kandyan Succession Ordinance No. 23 of 1917	1	4	0	0	consolidated
Registration of Documents Ordinance No. 23 of 1927	1	50	5	15	consolidated
Muslim Intestate Succession Ordinance No. 10 of 1931	1	4	0	0	consolidated
Buddhist Temporalities Ordinance No. 19 of 1931	2	44	1	11	consolidated
Land Settlement Ordinance No. 20 of 1931	3	33	1	4	consolidated
State Land (Claims) Ordinance No. 21 of 1931	3	7	0	0	consolidated
Land Development Ordinance No. 19 of 1935	2	143	0	13	consolidated

Enactment	Cat.	Sections	Amend.	Fold.	Edition
Bank of Ceylon Ordinance No. 53 of 1938	3	59	0	13	consolidated
Urban Councils Ordinance No. 61 of 1939	3	263	0	48	consolidated
Land Registers (Reconstructed Folios) Ordinance No. 18 of 1945	2	9	0	1	consolidated
Town and Country Planning Ordinance No. 13 of 1946	3	95	1	5	consolidated
State Lands Ordinance No. 8 of 1947	3	113	0	2	consolidated
Municipal Councils Ordinance No. 29 of 1947	3	349	0	42	consolidated
Registration of Old Deeds and Instruments Ordinance No. 35 of 1947	3	12	0	0	consolidated
Thesawalamai Pre-emption Ordinance No. 59 of 1947	1	14	0	0	consolidated
Mortgage Act No. 6 of 1949	2	126	0	6	consolidated
Land Acquisition Act No. 9 of 1950	2	73	3	7	consolidated
National Housing Act No. 37 of 1954	3	125	1	6	consolidated
Tea and Rubber Estates (Control of Fragmentation) Act No. 2 of 1958	1	29	1	1	as enacted
People's Bank Act No. 29 of 1961	3	63	3	7	consolidated
Local Authorities Housing Act No. 14 of 1964	3	14	1	1	consolidated
Nindagama Lands Act No. 30 of 1968	3	30	0	0	consolidated
Land Reform Law No. 1 of 1972	2	83	4	5	consolidated
Apartment Ownership Law No. 11 of 1973	1	50	3	4	consolidated
State Mortgage and Investment Bank Law No. 13 of 1975	3	88	3	3	consolidated
Urban Development Authority Law No. 41 of 1978	2	56	0	6	consolidated
National Housing Development Authority Act No. 17 of 1979	3	91	5	5	consolidated
Land Grants (Special Provisions) Act No. 43 of 1979	2	20	0	0	consolidated
Stamp Duty Act No. 43 of 1982	1	75	0	10	consolidated
Western Province Financial Statute No. 6 of 1990	1	108	0	0	consolidated
Registration of Title Act No. 21 of 1998	1	75	0	0	unconfirmed
Survey Act No. 17 of 2002	3	68	0	0	as enacted
Stamp Duty (Special Provisions) Act No. 12 of 2006	1	16	1	1	consolidated
Companies Act No. 7 of 2007	1	534	1	1	consolidated
Land (Restrictions on Alienation) Act No. 38 of 2014	1	26	2	2	consolidated
Revocation of Irrevocable Deeds of Gift on the Ground of Gross Ingratitude Act No. 5 of 2017	1	7	0	0	as enacted